RRB NTPC GK / General Awareness

High-Yield Medieval History Practice Questions (State PSC & SSC CGL Solved Archive)

■■ Part 1: Maratha Empire & Later Kingdoms

Question 1 — Exam Source: UPPSC PCS Pre (2020) & MPSC State Services Pre (2022)

In Chhatrapati Shivaji's Ashta Pradhan (Council of Ministers), which official was designated as the 'Sumant' or 'Dabir'?

A) Finance and Revenue Minister
B) Military Commander-in-Chief
C) Foreign Minister and Master of Ceremonies
D) Ecclesiastical Head and Charities Minister

Correct Answer: C) Foreign Minister and Master of Ceremonies

Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj created a highly structured central administration called the Ashta Pradhan (a council of eight ministers). Every minister except the Nyayadhish (Chief Justice) and Panditrao (High Priest) was expected to lead military commands when needed. The Sumant (also termed Dabir) managed foreign diplomacy, received foreign ambassadors, sent envoys to other states, and briefed the king on cross-border political dynamics.

Designation	Core Responsibility	Modern Equivalent
Peshwa (Mukhya Pradhan)	General administration & state welfare	Prime Minister
Amatya (Mazumdar)	Managing state accounts, income & expenditure	Finance Minister
Waqia-Navis (Mantri)	Intelligence, records, household affairs	Home Minister
Surunavis (Sachiv)	Verifying royal correspondence & official edits	Head of Secretariat
Sumant (Dabir)	Foreign alliances, external intelligence & protocol	Foreign Minister
Senapati (Sar-i-Naubat)	Military recruitment, training, organization	Defense Chief

Question 2 — Exam Source: BPSC CCE Pre (2018) & MPPSC Pre (2021)

What was the exact proportion of land revenue collected as 'Chauth' by the Marathas from the neighboring Mughal or non-Swarajya territories?

A) One-tenth (10%) of the total agricultural produce

B) One-fourth (25%) of the standard land revenue

C) One-third (33.3%) as a transit duty

D) Half (50%) of the crown lands

Correct Answer: B) One-fourth (25%) of the standard land revenue

> The Maratha tax structure was divided into internal revenue (within the sovereign zone called Swarajya) and external collections from frontier regions.
>
> - **Chauth (25%):** Nominally one-fourth of the land revenue. It acted as a protection fee. By paying Chauth, a non-Maratha state or Mughal province secured a guarantee that the Maratha army would not raid their lands and would defend them from external threats.
> - **Sardeshmukhi (10%):** An additional 10% levy collected on top of the regular revenue. Shivaji Maharaj claimed this as the hereditary Sardeshmukh (Supreme Head Desai) of the Maratha nation.

Question 3 — Exam Source: UPPSC RO/ARO Pre (2021) & WBPSC Miscellaneous Pre (2019)

Which treaty brought an end to the First Anglo-Maratha War in 1782, restoring the status quo and securing twenty years of peace between the Maratha Empire and the British East India Company?

A) Treaty of Purandar (1776)

B) Treaty of Bassein (1802)

C) Treaty of Salbai (1782)

D) Treaty of Wadgaon (1779)

Correct Answer: C) Treaty of Salbai (1782)

> The First Anglo-Maratha War (1775–1782) began due to British interference in the internal succession disputes of the Peshwas. After years of fighting—highlighted by a Maratha victory at the Battle of Wadgaon—the British recognized that a decisive military breakthrough was unlikely. Mahadji Shinde, the brilliant Maratha statesman and general, mediated the Treaty of Salbai in 1782. Under this treaty, the British recognized Madhav Rao Narayan as the rightful Peshwa and returned captured territories, establishing peace between both empires for two decades.

Question 4 — Exam Source: SSC CGL Tier-1 (Last Year Paper)

Which of the following groups formed the backbone/bulk of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj's army and were peasant-warriors of Maratha society?

A) Zamindars

B) Kunbis

C) Mansabdars

D) Pledgers

Correct Answer: B) Kunbis

> The Kunbis were a community of traditional agricultural cultivators and peasants in the Maharashtra region. Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj brilliantly mobilized these local agrarian communities into highly mobile peasant-warrior forces. Because they were intimately familiar with the rugged, mountainous terrain of the Western Ghats, the Kunbi infantry formed the foundational operational strength of the Maratha military, proving exceptionally lethal in executing Ganimi Kava (guerrilla warfare tactics).

Question 5 — Exam Source: SSC CGL Tier-1 (Last Year Paper)

In the context of the Ashta Pradhan system introduced by Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj, match the official with their corresponding responsibilities:

1. Peshwa — A. Foreign Minister
2. Amatya — B. Head of Correspondence / Royal Scribe
3. Sachiva / Shurunavis — C. Finance Minister / Accountant
4. Sumant / Dabir — D. Prime Minister / General Administration

A) 1-A, 2-B, 3-C, 4-D

B) 1-D, 2-C, 3-B, 4-A

C) 1-D, 2-B, 3-C, 4-A

D) 1-C, 2-D, 3-A, 4-B

Correct Answer: B) 1-D, 2-C, 3-B, 4-A

> The Ashta Pradhan was an advisory council of eight ministers instituted to streamline Maratha governance. Modern exam trends test complex multi-variable alignments instead of isolated single facts:
>
> - **Peshwa (Mukhya Pradhan):** Looked after the general welfare, administration, and supreme leadership in the ruler's absence.
> - **Amatya (Mazumdar):** Managed the financial accounting, state revenues, and expenditures.
> - **Sachiva (Surunavis):** Handled royal correspondence, verified drafts, and oversaw state documents.
> - **Sumant (Dabir):** Functioned as the Foreign Minister, managing relationships with external powers and welcoming foreign dignitaries.

■■ Part 2: Bhakti & Sufi Movements

Question 6 — Exam Source: MPSC State Services Pre (2021)

Which Varkari saint of Maharashtra composed the 'Eknathi Bhagavata', a celebrated vernacular commentary and adaptation of the 11th Skandha of the Bhagavata Purana?

A) Sant Dnyaneshwar
B) Sant Tukaram
C) Sant Namdev
D) Sant Eknath

Correct Answer: D) Sant Eknath

> The Bhakti tradition in Maharashtra was dominated by the Varkari Sect, who focused their devotion on Lord Vitthala (a form of Krishna) at Pandharpur. The movement sought to democratize spirituality by choosing local, vernacular speech over high Sanskrit. Sant Eknath (16th century) was a pioneer who insisted that Marathi was just as capable of expressing complex spiritual truths as Sanskrit. He wrote the Eknathi Bhagavata, completed the epic Bhavartha Ramayana, and meticulously edited the text of Sant Dnyaneshwar's classic work to preserve its authenticity.

Question 7 — Exam Source: Assam PSC CCE Pre & WBCS Pre (High Potential NTA Trend)

With reference to the Bhakti movement in Eastern India, the unique socio-religious institutional centers known as 'Sattras' (monasteries) and 'Namghars' (prayer halls) were introduced by which of the following saints?

A) Chaitanya Mahaprabhu
B) Srimanta Sankardeva
C) Ramananda
D) Guru Nanak Dev

Correct Answer: B) Srimanta Sankardeva

> Srimanta Sankardeva (15th–16th century) was the fountainhead of the Neo-Vaishnavite movement in Assam, preaching absolute devotion to Lord Krishna (Ekasarana Dharma). To anchor this socio-religious wave democratically across all layers of society, he established **Sattras** (institutional monasteries that served as vibrant hubs for art, dramatic performance, and philosophy) and **Namghars** (communal prayer halls where people of all social extractions gathered together to chant hymns). These centers remain the bedrock of the region's cultural landscape.

Question 8 — Exam Source: UPPSC PCS Pre & RPSC RAS Pre (High Potential NTA Trend)

In the context of the Sufi movement in medieval India, what did the term 'Malfuzat' precisely refer to?

A) The musical assemblies (Sama) organized to achieve spiritual ecstasy

B) The revenue-free land grants allocated to Sufi hospices by the ruling Sultan

C) The recorded conversations, discourses, and statements of a Sufi saint compiled by their disciples

D) The succession certificates issued by a Pir to declare his spiritual heir

Correct Answer: C) The recorded conversations, discourses, and statements of a Sufi saint compiled by their disciples

> **Malfuzat** represents a core genre of medieval Indo-Persian literature containing verbatim transcripts, ethical remarks, and conversations held by a Sufi master (Pir or Sheikh) inside his hospice (Khanqah). A prominent example is the *Fawa'id-al-Fu'ad*, which preserved the spiritual discourses of the celebrated Chishti saint Hazrat Nizamuddin Auliya as compiled by his disciple Amir Hasan Sijzi Dehlvi. This genre provides vital historical texture regarding daily subcontinental social dynamics. Other terms include: musical assemblies (*Sama*), hospices (*Khanqah*), and spiritual succession certificates (*Khilafatnama*).

Question 9 — Exam Source: RAS/RTS Rajasthan Pre (2021) & UPPSC PCS Pre (2019)

Which medieval Bhakti philosopher and theologian propounded the school of 'Shuddhadvaita' (Pure Non-dualism) and founded the devotional path known as Pushtimarga?

A) Ramanuja

B) Madhvacharya

C) Nimbarka

D) Vallabhacharya

Correct Answer: D) Vallabhacharya

> The Bhakti movement was anchored by distinct philosophical systems (Darshanas) developed by major Acharyas. Vallabhacharya (1479–1531 AD) established the school of Shuddhadvaita (Pure Non-dualism), which taught that the entire universe is a manifestation of the Supreme Brahman (Krishna) without the distorting layer of illusion (Maya). He introduced Pushtimarga (The Path of Divine Grace), teaching that liberation is attained through unconditional, loving devotion to Krishna.
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> **Summary of Philosophical Traditions:**
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> - Adi Shankaracharya: Advaita (Absolute Non-dualism)
> - Ramanujacharya: Vishishtadvaita (Qualified Non-dualism)
> - Madhvacharya: Dvaita (Dualism)
> - Nimbarkacharya: Dvaitadvaita (Dualistic Non-dualism)
> - Vallabhacharya: Shuddhadvaita (Pure Non-dualism)

Question 10 — Exam Source: UKPSC Uttarakhand PCS Pre (2022) & BPSC Pre (2015)

Which polymath, musician, poet, and historian of the Delhi Sultanate famously titled himself 'Tuti-e-Hind' (The Parrot of India) and was a disciple of Nizamuddin Auliya?

A) Ziauddin Barani

B) Hasan Dehlvi

C) Amir Khusrau

D) Malik Muhammad Jayasi

Correct Answer: C) Amir Khusrau

> Amir Khusrau (1253–1325 AD) was a prominent cultural figure of medieval India. As a close disciple of the Chishti saint Hazrat Nizamuddin Auliya, he infused Sufi mysticism into his art and served in the courts of seven successive Delhi Sultans, including Alauddin Khalji. Proud of his Indian heritage, he declared himself the Tuti-e-Hind (The Parrot of India). Khusrau played a key role in the synthesis of Persian and Indian cultures. He is credited with introducing the Qawwali style of devotional music, innovating the Ghazal format in the subcontinent, and blending Persian with early Hindavi poetry.